

ANCIENT ORDER OF FREE GARDENERS
Choosing the Right Name for Your Free Gardener Lodge
A guide for founders continuing a centuries-old tradition

Founding a lodge is one of the most meaningful acts a Free Gardener can undertake. In our tradition, a lodge name is never chosen lightly. It becomes a banner under which members gather, a symbol of the virtues they cultivate, and a living link to the long line of Gardeners who have tended this fraternity since the 1600s. A well-chosen name roots your lodge in its place, its people, and its purpose. It tells a story about who you are and what you hope to grow.

Below are the key considerations to guide you in selecting a name worthy of the Order and of your future members.

1. Begin With Your Landscape: Local Plants, Trees, and Crops

Free Gardeners have always drawn inspiration from the natural world around them. Look to the plants that define your region:

- Native trees (oak, maple, cedar, cypress, pine)
- Local crops (corn, wheat, sugarcane, tobacco, cotton, apples, grapes)
- Wildflowers and medicinal plants (goldenrod, echinacea, sage, violet, magnolia)
- Plants with cultural or historical significance in your state or town

Ask yourself: *What grows here? What thrives here? What do these plants teach us about resilience, service, or community?*

A lodge named for a local plant becomes instantly recognizable and deeply rooted in its home soil.

2. Consider the Symbolism of the Plant or Tree

Every plant carries a story. Many have spiritual, medicinal, or cultural meanings that align beautifully with the lessons of the Order.

Examples of symbolic associations:

- Oak – strength, endurance, justice
- Rose – love, secrecy, the unfolding of wisdom
- Laurel – honor, achievement, victory
- Cedar – protection, healing, steadfastness
- Iris – faith, hope, valor
- Vine – fellowship, interdependence, shared labor

Choose a plant whose meaning reflects the character you want your lodge to embody.

3. Reflect on the Degree Ceremonies and Their Lessons

The Free Gardener degrees—Apprentice, Journeyman, and Master—are rich with moral teachings. Many lodges historically chose names that echoed these virtues:

- Love
- Industry
- Harmony
- Wisdom
- Charity
- Fidelity
- Hope
- Unity
- Perseverance

You may choose a plant that symbolizes one of these virtues, or pair a virtue with a local plant (for example, *Harmony Oak Lodge*).

4. Honor Local History: Gardens, Gardeners, and Farmers

Your lodge name can also pay tribute to:

- Historic gardens or estates
- Notable gardeners, farmers, botanists, or horticulturalists from your region
- Agricultural traditions that shaped your community
- Local festivals or crops that define your area

This approach ties your lodge to the people who cultivated the land long before you.

5. Consider the Identity You Want Your Lodge to Project

Think about the qualities you want your lodge to be known for:

- Strength
- Wisdom
- Compassion
- Growth
- Stewardship
- Fellowship
- Renewal

Then ask: *What plant, tree, or flower embodies that quality?*

This creates a name that is both symbolic and aspirational.

6. Ground the Name in Your Location

Including your state, town, county, or region helps anchor your lodge in its community and distinguishes it from others.

Examples:

- Rose of London Lodge
- Dallas Bluebell Lodge
- Fields of Kansas Lodge
- Carolina Oak Lodge

A location-based name signals pride in place and invites local members to feel at home.

7. Learn From the Names of Historical Free Gardener Lodges

Throughout the 18th–20th centuries, lodges across Scotland, England, and abroad used names that blended nature, virtue, and locality. Examples include:

- Rose of Sharon Lodge
- Thistle Lodge
- Vine and Fig Tree Lodge
- Olive Branch Lodge
- Lily of the Valley Lodge
- Acorn Lodge
- Gardeners' Glory Lodge
- Hope Lodge
- St. Andrew's Lodge
- Green Oak Lodge
- Ivy Lodge

These names remind us that the Order has always used nature as a moral teacher and a unifying symbol.

8. Understand the Significance of Naming a Lodge

Choosing a lodge name is not just administrative—it is ceremonial. It places your lodge within the living history of the Order and declares your intentions to future generations.

A lodge name:

- Becomes part of the lineage of Free Gardener history
- Reflects the virtues you pledge to cultivate
- Serves as a beacon to seekers
- Connects your members to the land and its lessons
- Carries your lodge's identity long after the founders have passed

In the old days, a lodge name was spoken with pride, stitched into aprons, carved into gavels, and written into minute books that still survive today. Your lodge's name will one day be part of that same story.

9. Test the Name with Your Founding Members

Once you have a few strong candidates:

- Say them aloud
- Imagine them on a charter
- Picture them on regalia
- Consider how they will sound in ceremony
- Ask whether the name will still feel meaningful in 50 or 100 years

A good lodge name should feel timeless, dignified, and rooted.

10. Let the Name Be a Seed

The name you choose is the first seed your lodge plants. From it, your traditions, culture, and identity will grow. Choose a name that inspires you, honors your region, and reflects the virtues you hope to cultivate together.